

'A thing agreed upon that you should burn my house!' vociferated D'Artagnan, snatching the brand from the hand of the incendiary, and striking him with it across the face. The second wanted to assist his comrade, but Raoul, seizing him by the middle, threw him out of the window, whilst D'Artagnan pushed his man down the stairs. Raoul, first disengaged, tore the burning wainscoting down, and threw it flaming into the chamber. At a glance D'Artagnan saw there was nothing to be feared from the fire, and sprang to the window. The disorder was at its height. The air was filled with simultaneous cries of 'To the fire!' 'To the death!' 'To the halter!' 'To the stake!' 'Vive Colbert!' 'Vive le roi!' The group which had forced the culprits from the hands of the archers had drawn close to the house, which appeared to be the goal towards which they dragged them. Menneville was at the head of this group, shouting louder than all the others, 'To the fire! to the fire! Vive Colbert! D'Artagnan began to comprehend what was meant. They wanted to burn the condemned, and his house was to serve as a funeral pile.

'Halt, there!' cried he, sword in hand, and one foot upon the window. 'Menneville, what do you want to do?'

'Monsieur d'Artagnan,' cried the latter, 'give way, give way!'

'To the fire! to the fire with the thieves! Vive Colbert!'

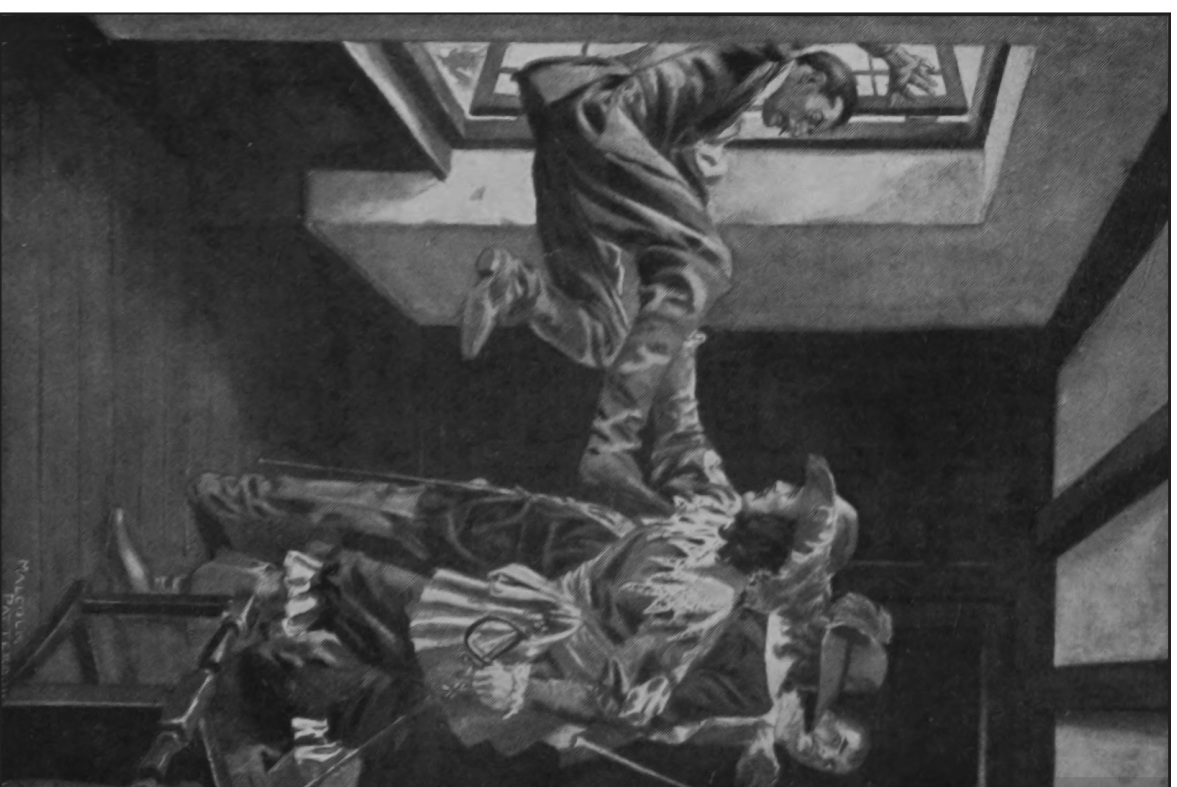
These cries exasperated D'Artagnan. '*Mordieu*!' said he. 'What! burn the poor devils who are only condemned to be hung? that is infamous!'

Before the door, however, the mass of anxious spectators, rolled back against the walls, had become more thick, and closed up the way. Menneville and his men, who were dragging along the culprits, were within ten paces of the door.

Menneville made a last effort. 'Passage! passage!' cried he, pistol in hand.

'Burn them! burn them!' repeated the crowd. 'The Image-de-Notre-Dame is on fire! Burn the thieves! burn the monopolists in the Image-de-Notre-Dame!'

There now remained no doubt, it was plainly D'Artagnan's house that was their object. D'Artagnan remembered the old cry, always so effective from his mouth: '*À moi!* mousquetaires!' shouted he, with the voice of a giant, with one of those voices which dominate over cannon, the sea, the tempest. '*À moi!* mousquetaires!' And suspending himself by the arm from the balcony, he allowed himself to drop amidst the crowd, which began to draw back from a house that rained men. Raoul was on the ground as soon as he, both sword in



RAOUL THREW HIM OUT OF THE WINDOW

hand. All the musketeers on the Place heard that challenging cry—all turned round at that cry, and recognized D'Artagnan. 'To the captain, to the captain!' cried they, in their turn. And the crowd opened before them as though before the prow of a vessel. At that moment D'Artagnan and Menneville found themselves face to face. 'Passage, passage!' cried Menneville, seeing that he was within an arm's length from the door.

'No one passes here,' said D'Artagnan.

'Take that, then!' said Menneville, firing his pistol almost within an arm's length. But before the cock fell, D'Artagnan had struck up Menneville's arm with the hilt of his sword and passed the blade through his body.

'I told you plainly to keep yourself quiet,' said D'Artagnan to Menneville, who rolled at his feet.

'Passage! passage!' cried the companions of Menneville, at first terrified, but soon recovering, when they found they had only to do with two men. But those two men were hundred-armed giants; the swords flew about in their hands like the burning glaive of the archangel. They pierce with its point, strike with the flat, cut with the edge; every stroke brings down a man. 'For the king!' cried D'Artagnan, to every man he struck at, that is to say, to every man that fell. This cry became the charging word for the musketeers, who, guided by it, joined D'Artagnan. During this time the archers, recovering from the panic they had undergone, charge the aggressors in the rear, and regular as mill strokes, overturn or knock down all that opposed them. The crowd, which sees swords gleaming, and drops of blood flying in the air—the crowd falls back and crushes itself. At length cries for mercy and of despair resound; that is, the farewell of the vanquished. The two condemned are again in the hands of the archers. D'Artagnan approaches them, seeing them pale and sinking: 'Console yourselves, poor men,' said he, 'you will not undergo the frightful torture with which these wretches threatened you. The king has condemned you to be hung: you shall only be hung. Go on, hang them, and it will be over.'

There is no longer anything going on at the 'Image-de-Notre-Dame.' The fire has been extinguished with two turns of wine in default of water. The conspirators have fled by the garden. The archers are dragging the culprits to the gibbets. From this moment the affair did not occupy much time. The executioner, heedless about operating according to the rules of the art, made such

those men, of whom D'Artagnan never lost sight, fell upon the escort, which in vain endeavoured to stand against them. Behind these men was the crowd. Then commenced, amidst a frightful tumult, as frightful a confusion. This time there was something more than cries of expectation or cries of joy, there were cries of pain. Halberds struck men down, swords ran through them, muskets were discharged at them. The confusion became then so great that D'Artagnan could no longer distinguish anything. Then, from this chaos, suddenly surged something like a visible intention, like a will pronounced. The condemned had been torn from the hands of the guards, and were being dragged towards the house of 'L'Image-de-Notre-Dame.' Those who dragged them shouted, 'Vive Colbert!' The people hesitated, not knowing which they ought to fall upon, the archers or the aggressors. What stopped the people was, that those who cried 'Vive Colbert!' began to cry, at the same time, 'No halter! no halter! to the fire! to the fire! burn the thieves! burn the extortioners!' This cry, shouted with an ensemble, obtained enthusiastic success. The populace had come to witness an execution, and here was an opportunity offered them of performing one themselves. It was this that must be most agreeable to the populace: therefore, they ranged themselves immediately on the party of the aggressors against the archers, crying with the minority, which had become, thanks to them, the most compact majority: 'Yes, yes: to the fire with the thieves! Vive Colbert!'

'*Morlions!*' exclaimed D'Artagnan, 'this begins to look serious.'

One of the men who remained near the chimney approached the window, a firebrand in his hand. 'Ah, ah!' said he, 'it gets warm.' Then, turning to his companion: 'There is the signal,' added he, and he immediately applied the burning brand to the wainscoting. Now, this cabaret of the Image-de-Notre-Dame was not a very newly built house, and therefore, did not require much entreating to take fire. In a second the boards began to crackle, and the flames arose sparkling to the ceiling. A howling from without replied to the shouts of the incendiaries. D'Artagnan, who had not seen what passed, from being engaged at the window, felt, at the same time, the smoke which choked him and the fire that scorched him. '*Holla!*' cried he, turning round, 'is the fire here? Are you drunk or mad, my masters?'

The two men looked at each other with an air of astonishment. 'In what?' asked they of D'Artagnan; 'was it not a thing agreed upon?'

were exchanged, hands given and taken. D'Arragnan remarked among the groups, and those groups the most animated, the face of the cavalier whom he had seen enter by the door of communication from his garden, and who had gone upstairs to harangue the drinkers. That man was organizing troops and giving orders.

'*Mordieux!*' said D'Arragnan to himself, 'I was not deceived; I know that man,—it is Menneville. What the devil is he doing here?'

A distant murmur, which became more distinct by degrees, stopped this reflection, and drew his attention another way. This murmur was occasioned by the arrival of the culprits; a strong picket of archers preceded them, and appeared at the angle of the arcade. The entire crowd now joined as if in one cry; all the cries united formed one immense howl. D'Arragnan saw Raoul was becoming pale, and he slapped him roughly on the shoulder. The fire-keepers turned round on hearing the great cry, and asked what was going on. 'The condemned are arrived,' said D'Arragnan. 'That's well,' replied they, again replenishing the fire. D'Arragnan looked at them with much uneasiness; it was evident that these men who were making such a fire for no apparent purpose had some strange intentions. The condemned appeared upon the Place. They were walking, the executioner before them, whilst fifty archers formed a hedge on their right and their left. Both were dressed in black; they appeared pale, but firm. They looked impatiently over the people's heads, standing on tip-toe at every step. D'Arragnan remarked this. '*Mordieux!*' cried he, 'they are in a great hurry to get a sight of the gibbet!' Raoul drew back, without, however, having the power to leave the window. Terror even has its attractions.

'To the death! to the death!' cried fifty thousand voices.

'Yes; to the death!' howled a hundred frantic others, as if the great mass had given them the reply.

'To the halter! to the halter!' cried the great whole; 'Vive le roi!'

'Well,' said D'Arragnan, 'this is droll; I should have thought it was M. Colbert who had caused them to be hung.'

There was, at this moment, a great rolling movement in the crowd, which stopped for a moment the march of the condemned. The people of a bold and resolute mien, whom D'Arragnan had observed, by dint of pressing, pushing, and lifting themselves up, had succeeded in almost touching the hedge of archers. The cortège resumed its march. All at once, to cries of 'Vive Colbert!'

haste that he dispatched the condemned in a couple of minutes. In the meantime the people gathered around D'Arragnan,—they felicitated, they cheered him. He wiped his brow, streaming with sweat, and his sword, streaming with blood. He shrugged his shoulders at seeing Menneville writhing at his feet in the last convulsions. And, while Raoul turned away his eyes in compassion, he pointed to the musketeers the gibbets laden with their melancholy fruit. 'Poor devils!' said he, 'I hope they died blessing me, for I saved them with great difficulty.' These words caught the ear of Menneville at the moment when he himself was breathing his last sigh. A dark, ironical smile flitted across his lips; he wished to reply, but the effort hastened the snapping of the chord of life—he expired.

'Oh! all this is very frightful!' murmured Raoul: 'let us be gone, monsieur le chevalier.'

'You are not wounded?' asked D'Arragnan.

'Not at all; thank you.'

'That's well! Thou art a brave fellow, *mordieux!* The head of the father, and the arm of Porthos. Ah! if he had been here, good Porthos, you would have seen something worth looking at.' Then as if by way of remembrance—

'But where the devil can that brave Porthos be?' murmured D'Arragnan.

'Come, chevalier, pray come away,' urged Raoul.

'One minute, my friend; let me take my thirty-seven and a half pistols, and I am at your service. The house is a good property,' added D'Arragnan, as he entered the 'Image-de-Notre-Dame,' 'but decidedly, even if it were less profitable, I should prefer its being in another quarter.'

Chapter LXII

Vive Colbert!



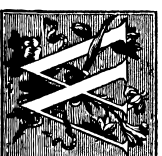
THE spectacle which the Grève now presented was a frightful one. The heads, levelled by the perspective, extended afar, thick and agitated as the ears of corn in a vast plain. From time to time a fresh report, or a distant rumour, made the heads oscillate and thousands of eyes flash. Now and then there were great movements. All those ears of corn bent, and became waves more agitated than those of the ocean, which rolled from the extremities to the centre, and beat, like the tides, against the hedge of archers who surrounded the gibbets. Then the handles of the halberds were let fall upon the heads and shoulders of the rash invaders; at times, also, it was the steel as well as the wood, and, in that case, a large empty circle was formed around the guard; a space conquered upon the extremities, which underwent, in their turn the oppression of the sudden movement, which drove them against the parapets of the Seine. From the window, that commanded a view of the whole Place, D'Artagnan saw, with interior satisfaction, that such of the musketeers and guards as found themselves involved in the crowd, were able, with blows of their fists and the hilts of their swords, to keep room. He even remarked that they had succeeded, by that esprit de corps which doubles the strength of the soldier, in getting together in one group to the amount of about fifty men; and that, with the exception of a dozen stragglers whom he still saw rolling here and there, the nucleus was complete, and within reach of his voice. But it was not the musketeers and guards that drew the attention of D'Artagnan. Around the gibbets, and particularly at the entrances to the arcade of Saint-Jean, moved a noisy mass, a busy mass; daring faces, resolute demeanours were to be seen here and there, mingled with silly faces and indifferent demeanours; signals

‘Without doubt they have,’ said D’Artagnan, anxious to know what was going on; ‘why should I be here else, if it were not for that?’

‘Then place yourself at the window, if you please, and observe.’ D’Artagnan smiled in his moustache, made a sign to Raoul, and placed himself at the window.

Chapter LXIII

How M. d'Eymeris's Diamond Passed into the Hands of M. d'Artagnan



IN THE midst of this violent, noisy, and bloody scene was passing on the Grève, several men, barricaded behind the gate of communication with the garden, replaced their swords in their sheaths, assisted one among them to mount a ready saddled horse which was waiting in the garden, and like a flock of startled birds, fled in all directions, some climbing the walls, others rushing out at the gates with all the fury of a panic. He who mounted the horse, and gave him the spur so sharply that the animal was near leaping the wall, this cavalier, we say, crossed the Place Baudoyer, passed like lightning before the crowd in the streets, riding against, running over and knocking down all that came in his way; and, ten minutes after, arrived at the gates of the superintendent, more out of breath than his horse. The Abbé Fouquet, at the clatter of hoofs on the pavement, appeared at a window of the court, and before even the cavalier had set foot to the ground, ‘Well! Danicamp?’ cried he, leaning half out of the window.

‘Well, it is all over,’ replied the cavalier.

‘All over!’ cried the Abbé. ‘Then they are saved?’

‘No, monsieur,’ replied the cavalier, ‘they are hung.’

‘Hung!’ repeated the Abbé, turning pale. A lateral door suddenly opened, and Fouquet appeared in the chamber, pale, distracted, with lips half opened,

breathing a cry of grief and anger. He stopped upon the threshold to listen to what was addressed from the court to the window.

'Miserable wretches!' said the Abbé, 'you did not fight, then?'

'Like lions.'

'Say like cowards.'

'Monsieur!'

'A hundred men accustomed to war, sword in hand, are worth ten thousand archers in a surprise. Where is Menneville, that boaster, that braggart, who was to come back either dead or a conqueror?'

'Well, monsieur, he kept his word. He is dead!'

'Dead! Who killed him?'

'A demon disguised as a man, a giant armed with ten flaming swords—a madman, who at one blow extinguished the fire, put down the riot, and caused a hundred musketeers to rise up out of the pavement of the Grève.'

Fouquet raised his brow, streaming with sweat, murmuring, 'Oh! Lyodot and D'Eymetis! dead! dead! and I dishonoured.'

The Abbé turned round, and perceiving his brother, despairing and livid, 'Come, come,' said he, 'it is a blow of fate, monsieur; we must not lament thus. Our attempt has failed because God—'

'Be silent, Abbé! be silent!' cried Fouquet; 'your excuses are blasphemies.

Order that man up here, and let him relate the details of this terrible event.'

'But, brother—'

'Obey, monsieur!'

The Abbé made a sign, and in half a minute the man's step was heard upon the stairs. At the same time Gourville appeared behind Fouquet, like the guardian angel of the superintendent, pressing one finger on his lips to enjoin observation even amidst the bursts of his grief. The minister resumed all the serenity that human strength left at the disposal of a heart half broken with sorrow. Danicamp appeared. 'Make your report,' said Gourville.

'Monsieur,' replied the messenger, 'we received orders to carry off the prisoners, and to cry "Vive Colbert!" whilst carrying them off.'

'To burn them alive, was it not, Abbé?' interrupted Gourville.

'Yes, yes, the order was given to Menneville. Menneville knew what was to be done, and Menneville is dead.'

This news appeared rather to reassure Gourville than to sadden him.

which made a formidable accompaniment to the harangue of the orator. But it was soon finished, and all the people the cabaret contained came out, one after the other, in little groups, so that there only remained six in the chamber; one of these six, the man with the sword, took the cabaretier aside, engaging him in discourse more or less serious, whilst the others lit a great fire in the chimney-place—a circumstance rendered strange by the fine weather and the heat.

'It is very singular,' said D'Arragnan to Raoul, 'but I think I know those faces yonder.'

'Don't you think you can smell the smoke here?' said Raoul.

'I rather think I can smell a conspiracy,' replied D'Arragnan.

He had not finished speaking, when four of these men came down into the court, and without the appearance of any bad design, mounted guard at the door of communication, casting, at intervals, glances at D'Arragnan, which signified many things.

'*Mortiaux!*' said D'Arragnan, in a low voice, 'there is something going on.

Are you curious, Raoul?'

'According to the subject, chevalier.'

'Well, I am as curious as an old woman. Come a little more in front; we shall get a better view of the place. I would lay a wager that view will be something curious.'

'But you know, monsieur le chevalier, that I am not willing to become a passive and indifferent spectator of the death of the two poor devils.'

'And I, then—do you think I am a savage? We will go in again, when it is time to do so. Come along!' And they made their way towards the front of the house, and placed themselves near the window which, still more strangely than the rest, remained unoccupied. The two last drinkers, instead of looking out at this window, kept up the fire. On seeing D'Arragnan and his friend enter:—'Ah! ah! a reinforcement,' murmured they.

D'Arragnan jogged Raoul's elbow. 'Yes, my braves, a reinforcement,' said he; '*cordieu!* there is a famous fire. Whom are you going to cook?'

The two men uttered a shout of jovial laughter, and, instead of answering, threw on more wood. D'Arragnan could not take his eyes off them.

'I suppose,' said one of the fire-makers, 'they sent you to tell us the time—did not they?'

Look, there is yonder in the lower court a tree, and under the shade of that tree we shall breathe more freely than in this hot atmosphere of spilt wine.'

From the spot on which they had placed themselves the two new guests of the Image-de-Notre-Dame heard the ever-increasing hubbub of the tide of people, and lost neither a cry nor a gesture of the drinkers, at tables in the cabaret, or disseminated in the chambers. If D'Artagnan had wished to place himself as a vidette for an expedition, he could not have succeeded better. The tree under which he and Raoul were seated covered them with its already thick foliage; it was a low, thick chestnut-tree, with inclined branches, that cast their shade over a table so dilapidated the drinkers had abandoned it. We said that from this post D'Artagnan saw everything. He observed the goings and comings of the waiters; the arrival of fresh drinkers; the welcome, sometimes friendly, sometimes hostile, given to the newcomers by others already installed. He observed all this to amuse himself, for the thirty-seven and a half pistoles were a long time coming. Raoul recalled his attention to it. 'Monsieur,' said he, 'you do not hurry your tenant, and the condemned will soon be here. There will then be such a press we shall not be able to get out.'

'You are right,' said the musketeer; '*Hola!* oh! somebody there! *Mordieu!*' But it was in vain he cried and knocked upon the wreck of the old table, which fell to pieces beneath his fist; nobody came. D'Artagnan was preparing to go and seek the cabaretier himself, to force him to a definite explanation, when the door of the court in which he was with Raoul, a door which communicated with the garden situated at the back, opened, and a man dressed as a cavalier, with his sword in the sheath, but not at his belt, crossed the court without closing the door; and having cast an oblique glance at D'Artagnan and his companion, directed his course towards the cabaret itself, looking about in all directions with his eyes capable of piercing walls of consciences. 'Humph!' said D'Artagnan, 'my tenants are communicating. That, no doubt, now, is some amateur in hanging matters.' At the same moment the cries and disturbance in the upper chambers ceased. Silence, under such circumstances, surprises more than a twofold increase of noise. D'Artagnan wished to see what was the cause of this sudden silence. He then perceived that this man, dressed as a cavalier, had just entered the principal chamber, and was haranguing the tipplers, who all listened to him with the greatest attention. D'Artagnan would perhaps have heard his speech but for the dominant noise of the popular clamours,

'Yes, certainly to burn them alive,' said the Abbé, eagerly.

'Granted, monsieur, granted,' said the man, looking into the eyes and the faces of the two interlocutors, to ascertain what there was profitable or disadvantageous to himself in telling the truth.

'Now, proceed,' said Gourville.

'The prisoners,' cried Danicamp, 'were brought to the Grève, and the people, in a fury, insisted upon their being burnt instead of being hung.'

'And the people were right,' said the Abbé. 'Go on.'

'But,' resumed the man, 'at the moment the archers were broken, at the moment the fire was set to one of the houses of the Place destined to serve as a funeral-pile for the guilty, this fury, this demon, this giant of whom I told you, and who, we had been informed, was the proprietor of the house in question, aided by a young man who accompanied him, threw out of the window those who kept the fire, called to his assistance the musketeers who were in the crowd, leaped himself from the window of the first story into the Place, and plied his sword so desperately that the victory was restored to the archers, the prisoners were retaken, and Menneville killed. When once recaptured, the condemned were executed in three minutes.' Fouquet, in spite of his self-command, could not prevent a deep groan escaping him.

'And this man, the proprietor of the house, what is his name?' said the Abbé.

'I cannot tell you, not having even been able to get sight of him; my post had been appointed in the garden, and I remained at my post: only the affair was related to me as I repeat it. I was ordered, when once the affair was at an end, to come at best speed and announce to you the manner in which it finished. According to this order, I set out, full gallop, and here I am.'

'Very well, monsieur, we have nothing else to ask of you,' said the Abbé, more and more dejected, in proportion as the moment approached for finding himself alone with his brother.

'Have you been paid?' asked Gourville.

'Partly, monsieur,' replied Danicamp.

'Here are twenty pistols. Begone, monsieur, and never forget to defend, as this time has been done, the true interests of the king.'

'Yes, monsieur,' said the man, bowing and pocketing the money. After which he went out. Scarcely had the door closed after him when Fouquet,

who had remained motionless, advanced with a rapid step and stood between the Abbé and Gourville. Both of them at the same time opened their mouths to speak to him. 'No excuses,' said he, 'no recriminations against anybody. If I had not been a false friend I should not have confided to any one the care of delivering Lyodot and D'Eymeris. I alone am guilty; to me alone are reproaches and remorse due. Leave me, Abbé.'

'And yet, monsieur, you will not prevent me,' replied the latter, 'from endeavouring to find out the miserable fellow who has intervened to the advantage of M. Colbert in this so well-arranged affair; for, if it is good policy to love our friends dearly, I do not believe that is bad which consists in obstinately pursuing our enemies.'

'A truce to policy, Abbé; begone, I beg of you, and do not let me hear any more of you till I send for you; what we most need is circumsppection and silence. You have a terrible example before you, gentlemen: no reprisals, I forbid them.'

'There are no orders,' grumbled the Abbé, 'which will prevent me from avenging a family affront upon the guilty person.'

'And I,' cried Fouquet, in that imperative tone to which one feels there is nothing to reply, 'if you entertain one thought, one single thought, which is not the absolute expression of my will, I will have you cast into the Bastille two hours after that thought has manifested itself. Regulate your conduct accordingly, Abbé.'

The Abbé coloured and bowed. Fouquet made a sign to Gourville to follow him, and was already directing his steps towards his cabinet, when the usher announced with a loud voice: 'Monsieur le Chevalier d'Arragnan.'

'Who is he?' said Fouquet, negligently, to Gourville.

'An ex-lieutenant of his majesty's musketeers,' replied Gourville, in the same tone. Fouquet did not even take the trouble to reflect, and resumed his walk. 'I beg your pardon, monseigneur!' said Gourville, 'but I have remembered; this brave man has quitted the king's service, and probably comes to receive an instalment of some pension or other.'

'Devil take him!' said Fouquet, 'why does he choose his opportunity so ill?' 'Permit me then, monseigneur, to announce your refusal to him; for he is one of my acquaintance, and is a man whom, in our present circumstances, it would be better to have as a friend than an enemy.'

ribs of bronze not to cry thank you when the wrist made its play, or hearts of diamond not to be enchanted when such a bland smile enlivened the lips of the musketeer. Raoul, following his friend, cajoled the women who admired his beauty, pushed back the men who felt the rigidity of his muscles, and both opened, thanks to these manoeuvres, the compact and muddy tide of the populace. They arrived in sight of the two gibbets, from which Raoul turned away his eyes in disgust. As for D'Arragnan, he did not even see them; his house with its gabled roof, its windows crowded with the curious, attracted and even absorbed all the attention he was capable of. He distinguished in the Place and around the houses a good number of musketeers on leave, who, some with women, others with friends, awaited the crowning ceremony. What rejoiced him above all was to see that his tenant, the cabaretier, was so busy he hardly knew which way to turn. Three lads could not supply the drinkers. They filled the shop, the chambers, and the court, even. D'Arragnan called Raoul's attention to this concourse, adding: 'The fellow will have no excuse for not paying his rent. Look at those drinkers, Raoul, one would say they were jolly companions. *Mordieu!* why, there is no room anywhere!' D'Arragnan, however, contrived to catch hold of the master by the corner of his apron, and to make himself known to him.

'Ah, monsieur le chevalier,' said the cabaretier, half distracted, 'one minute if you please. I have here a hundred mad devils turning my cellar upside down.'

'The cellar, if you like, but not the money-box.'

'Oh, monsieur, your thirty-seven and a half pistoles are all counted out ready for you, upstairs in my chamber; but there are in that chamber thirty customers, who are sucking the staves of a little barrel of Oporto which I tapped for them this very morning. Give me a minute,—only a minute?'

'So be it; so be it.'

'I will go,' said Raoul, in a low voice, to D'Arragnan; 'his hilarity is vile!'

'Monsieur,' replied D'Arragnan, sternly, 'you will please to remain where you are. The soldier ought to familiarize himself with all kinds of spectacles. There are in the eye, when it is young, fibres which we must learn how to harden; and we are not truly generous and good save from the moment when the eye has become hardened, and the heart remains tender. Besides, my little Raoul, would you leave me alone here? That would be very wrong of you.'